



The 12 principles of animation

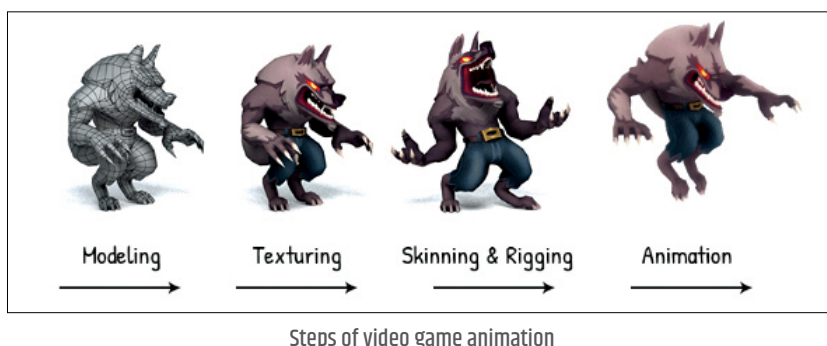
The guiding philosophies that designers use when coming up with effective animations. <https://dgit.in/apr20-27>



The hand made look

A study of how 3 videogames came up with the hand drawn look in their titles. <https://dgit.in/apr20-28>

Source: Ace Web and Animation Studios



physics (or outerworld physics, if your game demands that).

A game animator must also have a clear understanding of animation tools, processes and systems. Reskilling and upskilling in this field is almost mandatory every couple of years since the technology moves inexplicably fast. Also, within the technical skills they possess, they must attempt to keep breaking the barrier and finding out better techniques or methods to make their animation more efficient or of superior quality.

Lastly, you must know the nature of your field. Game animators are an integral part of the game development team. This is why they must accept the fluid nature of game development. There's no fixed hours since there's no telling how many test iterations it will take to make a game fun and functional at the same time. You may have to mold and adapt according to the other facets of the team and also work closely with designers, programmers, artists, audio technicians and more to bring your collective creations to life.

QUALIFICATIONS AND SKILLS

If you're looking into video game animation as a career path, you'd ideally want to pursue a degree at an arts school that has dedicated courses for animation. A bachelor's or master's degree in animation, art, computer graphics or illustration is best suited for aspiring game animators. Such courses proffer extensive training in 2-D and 3-D animation techniques and technologies and also teach you about modeling, game design, interactive design, art, texture and much more. However, artists that

do not have these particular educational qualifications can also obtain employment if they have the right combination of creativity as well as experience using animation software.

It usually takes about 2 to 4 years of working closely with video game animation technology to achieve proficiency. Programs such as After Effects, Flash, FinalCut Pro, Illustrator, Maya, Photoshop, Studio Max and other such video production and graphics programs are quite essential. Colleges, abroad as well as in India, offer classes to learn these programs. Additionally product vendors also provide tutorials and courses surrounding their software.

Some of the best 2-D animation tools for game development include Aseprite, Spine, Creature, Pyxel Edit and others, while the most sought-out 3-D animation software include 3ds Max, Motionbuilder, Blender, Cinema 4D, Maya. While Autodesk's Maya and Max are two of the most popular software, they are quite exorbitantly priced. Now, they are facing competition from a host of free offerings such as Blender.

Animators should also possess basic knowledge of processes common in the field such as polygon modelling, rigging, and skinning. They should have an intimate understanding of the animation export process and its abilities and limitations. This can help save time and increase iteration, which can be a deciding factor in whether your final product is merely acceptable or polished. Additionally, animators must also be familiar with game engines such as Unreal and Unity, which are now free. These are software that ultimately wrangle the

myriad aspects of a video game such as data creation and game assets together.

VARIOUS AREAS OF VIDEO GAME ANIMATION

There are not just one, but several different areas within video game animation that animators can specialise in. Large studios which typically boast of bigger teams have specialised animators that take care of different aspects of animation, however, in smaller studios animators typically have to adorn many hats. According to the book *Game Anim: Video Game Animation Explained* by Jonathan Cooper, a renowned game animator who led large projects such as the *Assassin's Creed* and *Mass Effect* series, these are the different areas of video game animation.

Player Character Animation

The animation of the motion of characters which are under the player's control.

Facial Animation

This is a crucial area to focus on since the animations on the face can be easily critiqued by even the most undiscerning player.

Cinematics and Cutscenes

An area of animation where one should have a knack for cinematography, staging and acting in order to add depth to the story, environment, and characters of the game.

Technical Animation

A working knowledge of processes such as character creation, rigging, skinning and implementation into the game.

NPC Animation

The demands of character animations often differ from those of nonplayer characters (NPCs) since they are not player-controlled and their actions are usually supported by AI.

Environmental and Prop Animation

Environments and props bring life to the listless locations in a game. A character's interaction with the environment is also extremely important in gameplay. 